National Overview

Current situation

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The food security situation in Haiti throughout 2015 and in the first two months of 2016 was affected in large part by the impact of the El Niño phenomenon on crop production. The El Niño-induced drought triggered losses of crops in all parts of the country, limiting food availability and resulting in high increases in prices for locally grown food crops.

In addition, the election crisis since last August has created an unhealthy business climate, which is limiting both public and private investment. The combined effects of these shocks are weakening the country's macroeconomic situation, accelerating the deterioration in the food security situation of very poor households.

Climatic hazards. The El Niño phenomenon remained active during both growing seasons for 2015, **with the lowest rainfall in 30 years across most areas during the spring season, and resulted in significant dry spells throughout the year**. There were water shortages in virtually all parts of the country, particularly on the Southern Peninsula and the Central Plateau and in the Sud-Est, Nord-Ouest, upper Artibonite, Nord-Est, and Ouest Departments. Rainfall levels in most of these areas were at barely 50 percent of figures for 2014, which, themselves, were below average.

One of the main effects was a **drop in surface water levels** and a sharp reduction in the discharge of rivers. A comparative study by the National Water Supply and Sanitation Bureau (DINEPA) puts the level of the water table in 2015 as much as 50 percent lower than in 2010. The growing cycle of bean crops planted between December and February in many parts of Sud-Est Department, for example, has been severely disrupted by the lack of water in irrigation canals.

However, according to the NOAA, during the last 30 days there have been near-average levels of rainfall across the country, which have helped to improve soil moisture. In addition, all parts of the island have been reporting seasonal surpluses of over 50 mm since December 2015. Recent vegetation indexes such as the NDVI show average or above-average conditions in most areas with the exception of the Nord-Ouest and Nord-Est Departments, where conditions are reportedly below average (Figure 1). There were even reports of flooding in the Nord Department at the beginning of February, which helped considerably improve soil moisture conditions in that area.

Central Plateau.

- **The SMART survey conducted by the Ministry of Health in November 2015 showed concerning levels of acute malnutrition among children between six and 59 months of age** in certain municipalities especially hard hit by the drought in 2015. With the steady deterioration in food security conditions, the prevalence of acute malnutrition in these communes are likely to stay high or possibly even worsen between February and June.

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- **Demand for farm labor**. There is currently a much lower than normal demand for labor with the poor harvests in January and February. There should be a gradual rise in demand by the beginning of March, peaking sometime in April/May though staying lower than usual. Middle-income and better-off households will probably not have the means with which to plant as large an area as usual during the first growing season. Poor households earn more than 30 percent of their annual income from farm labor. There should be a sizeable improvement in demand for labor between August and September, during the second growing season. As is the case every season, very poor households will wait to receive part of their wages before planting their own fields, which they generally start to do a little late, running the risk of missing the rainy season. Based on the more positive rainfall outlook for both growing seasons, there is a high likelihood that very poor households will successfully farm their land and harvest crops.

- The Central Bank has taken steps to reduce the money supply in circulation in an attempt to stabilize the exchange rate for the Haitian gourde. As a result, commercial banks have less liquidity with which to meet demand from their customers. This will tighten consumer credit and slow investment loans, which could affect economic activity, particularly job maintenance and creation.

Most likely food security outcomes

The failure of both main growing seasons in most crop-producing areas in 2015 exacerbated the already precarious food security situation after the heavy crop losses in 2014. According to the preliminary data emerging from a rapid assessment conducted by the CNSA in December 2015 in the worst drought-stricken areas, 72 percent of respondents reported having lost over 80 percent of their crops.

Very poor households normally earn as much as 60 percent of their income from farming activities and own-produced foods account for 20 percent of their food consumption. Other sources of income such as charcoal production, fishing, and migration cannot fully make up for these reported crop losses.